



# The RSM Family Emergency Binder Checklist

*Everything Your Family Would Need If Something Happened to You, in One Place*

By Darrell Thompson | Right Side of Money

**47% of American households say they'd feel the financial impact within six months if their primary wage earner died.** Only about one in four Americans has a will. And about three in four people overestimate what life insurance costs, so many never check. This checklist helps you close the gaps before your family ever has to find them. (Sources: 2026 Insurance Barometer Study, LIMRA and Life Happens; Caring.com 2025 Wills and Estate Planning Survey.)

## 01 The 6 Questions Your Family Would Face

### If something happened to you...

### What your family needs in place

#### 1. How do we pay the bills next month?

An emergency fund in its own account, and someone who can access it.

#### 2. How do we replace the income for years?

Income protection sized on purpose, not a guess or only what came with the job.

#### 3. Who decides for you if you can't?

A durable power of attorney and a health care directive.

#### 4. Who raises the kids, and who gets what?

A current will with a named guardian, and up-to-date

## 02 Find Your Real Coverage Number

Most people pick a round number that sounds good. This simple worksheet, sometimes called the DIME method, gives you a real starting point. It's a guide for your own planning, not a recommendation.

|                         |                                                                                          |          |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| <b>D: Debt</b>          | Credit cards, car loans, personal loans, and other debts your family would need paid off | \$ _____ |
| <b>I: Income</b>        | Your yearly income x the number of years your family would need it replaced              | \$ _____ |
| <b>M: Mortgage</b>      | What's left on your mortgage, or several years of rent                                   | \$ _____ |
| <b>E: Education</b>     | Future school or training costs for your children                                        | \$ _____ |
| <b>+ Final expenses</b> | Funeral and final costs                                                                  | \$ _____ |
| <b>- What you have</b>  | Existing coverage (including through work) and savings your family could use             | \$ _____ |
| <b>= Your gap</b>       | This is the amount of protection your family is missing today                            | \$ _____ |

**Watch the job coverage.** Life insurance through work is often one or two times your salary, and it usually ends or changes when you leave the job. Find out exactly what yours is and what happens to it if you leave.

**Don't forget disability.** The Social Security Administration estimates that just over one in four of today's 20-year-olds will become disabled before reaching full retirement age. A disability stops the paycheck while the bills keep coming.

## 03 The Paperwork Checklist

- A **current will** that names a **guardian** for any children under 18 (or a trust that covers it)
- **Beneficiaries checked** on every life insurance policy, 401(k), IRA, and bank or brokerage account. Beneficiary forms generally control who receives that money, even over a will
- A **durable power of attorney** naming who can handle your finances if you can't
- A **health care directive** (and HIPAA release) naming

## 04 What Goes in Your Family Emergency Binder

Keep it in one place your family knows about, like a fireproof box or a secure shared digital folder. List where things are and how to reach them. Never write full passwords on paper; record how to get in instead.

- **Every bank, retirement, and investment account:** institution, type, and last four digits
- **Every insurance policy:** life, disability, health, home, auto. Company, policy number, and agent contact
- **Monthly bills and autopays:** what's due, when, and from which account
- **Debts:** mortgage, car loans, credit cards, student loans, and any co-signed loans
- **Home and vehicles:** where the deed and titles are kept
- **Digital access:** your password manager's emergency contact, plus the legacy contact set up on your phone and email accounts
- **Employer benefits:** HR contact, group life and disability coverage, and pension or 401(k) details
- **Last two years of tax returns** and the name of whoever prepares them
- **Your wishes:** funeral preferences and any letters you want your family to read

### Key Contacts

| Who                            | Name | Phone or Email |
|--------------------------------|------|----------------|
| Insurance agent                |      |                |
| Attorney                       |      |                |
| Tax preparer                   |      |                |
| Employer HR                    |      |                |
| Bank or credit union           |      |                |
| Person who holds the spare key |      |                |

## 05 Build Your Emergency Cushion

| Stage          | Target                       | Why It Matters                                                                    |
|----------------|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Starter</b> | One month of essential bills | Covers most car repairs, medical bills, and surprise trips without a credit card. |
| <b>Solid</b>   |                              |                                                                                   |

## 06 The 30-Minute Family Meeting

A plan only works if the people who need it know it exists. Sit down with your spouse, partner, or the adult child who would step in, and cover these five things:

- **Where the binder is** and how to get into it
- **Who to call first** (use your Key Contacts list)
- **What protection you have** and roughly what it would provide
- **Who you've named** as guardian, power of attorney, and health care decision-maker, and why
- **A date to review it together** next year

**Debt doesn't simply disappear, and it doesn't always stay with you.** Generally, family members aren't personally responsible for a loved one's debts, but there are important exceptions: co-signers, joint account holders, and spouses in community property states, which include California. Debts are also usually paid from what you leave behind before your family receives anything. Ask a qualified professional how this works in your state.

**Want help with your plan?** Book a free Discovery Call with Darrell Thompson at [rightsideofmoney.com](https://rightsideofmoney.com) to walk through your Family Protection Readiness results and build a clear plan for your biggest gaps first. For the bigger picture, read about the Family Banking System in **Creating A Wealth Building Mindset 2nd Edition**.

Find more free quizzes, tools, and guides at [rightsideofmoney.com](https://rightsideofmoney.com) under Free Resources.

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